but unequivocal praise, admiration and respect.

So the roller-coaster ride began …

2005

After the Test series against England, my highest score in the five ODIs that follow is 20. I need runs. The first Test in Zimbabwe presents an opportunity to play a decent innings and secure my place on the forthcoming tour to the West Indies. I open our innings with Graeme Smith and, together, we take the score to 217 without loss before I lose patience, try to slog the left-spinner over mid-wicket and get myself out for 98.

The tour to the Caribbean is special, even if the public-address announcer in the drawn first Test in Georgetown, Guyana, can't pronounce my name. He attempts to introduce me as I walk out to open with Graeme but stumbles over his words, amusing the fielders and the crowd.

The Proteas are invited to attend a sponsor's function before the second Test in Port of Spain, Trinidad, and, while standing to one side, trying to keep my head down, I look up and see Brian Lara walking towards me. What could the celebrated West Indian batsman want with me? I start to panic.

'Hello,' he says.

'Er, hello,' I reply, scared, barely able to look him in the eye.

'I see they have trouble pronouncing your name, youngster,' he says, 'but I don't have a problem. It's A. B. D. E. V. I. L. L. I. E. R. S. You see, I can spell your name. You can play the game.'

With that, he turns and walks away, disappearing into the mass of people. I am stunned and excited at the same time, and immediately start looking for Mark Boucher in the crowd to tell him what has just happened, to tell him that one of the greatest batsmen of all time not only knows my name but says I can play.